Ares phone screen — call sheet

Fatima Khaire, Dartmouth Partners · Tuesday 13 October, 12:45–13:00 BST · ~15 minutes

READ THIS FIRST

She is a recruitment consultant, not a credit specialist. She is deciding one thing: can I put this person in front of Ares? She wants warmth, clarity and brevity. **Use ONE specific fact, not five.** No IRRs, no fund names beyond ARCC or ASIF, no fee structures. Over-teching this call is the main way to fail it.

1. "Tell me about yourself."

60–90 SECONDS. NOT THREE MINUTES.

Where you are academically → what drew you to finance → what specifically drew you to private markets → why you applied to Ares. **End on Ares** so it hands her the next question.

2. "Why Ares?"

TWO SENTENCES. WARM, NOT RECITED.

> *"Ares is credit-first by DNA rather than a private equity house that added credit later — it started in leveraged finance in 1997. And most of its fundraising comes from investors who already have money with them, which told me the client relationship is the actual engine of the business, not a support function."*

3. "Which team do you prefer?"

FLAGGED IN THE INVITE. IT IS COMING.

First choice + real reason + genuine openness to the second. Never "either is fine."

> *"Client Solutions first, though I'd honestly be happy with either — at Ares they sit in the same group. Client Solutions appeals because it sits across all four investment groups rather than inside one, so you learn the whole platform rather than one sleeve. And since most fundraising comes from existing investors, servicing and selling are really the same job."*

5. "Why private markets, not banking?"

HAVE A REAL ANSWER, NOT A DIPLOMATIC ONE.

You want long relationships and to understand a business properly, rather than moving transaction to transaction. The relationships here run for a decade or more.

6. "Where else are you applying?"

BE HONEST. NOBODY BELIEVES "ONLY ARES."

Name a couple honestly, then make clear Ares is your genuine first choice and you would accept. Do not signal you would rather be elsewhere.

7. Logistics — have these ready

FUMBLING HERE IS A NEEDLESS OWN GOAL.

Graduation date · internship availability / start date · London · **right to work / visa status** · notice on any other offers in play.

8. "Any questions for me?"

ALWAYS YES. PICK TWO.

1. What tends to separate candidates who do well at the Ares stage from those who don't?
2. How many stages follow this, and what format?
3. Is there a split in how many interns go into each team?

Then: ask for feedback afterwards. Dartmouth commit to giving it at every stage and almost nobody asks.

4. “What does the role involve?”

TESTING: DO YOU KNOW IT’S COMMERCIAL, NOT ADMIN?

Owning the relationship with the investors whose money Ares manages — reporting to them accurately, answering their questions, and helping them into the right products across the four investment groups.

If you want one fact in reserve

Only use it if she asks something that genuinely invites it: **“Around four fifths of their institutional fundraising comes from existing investors re-upping or buying a second product.”** It is simple, memorable, needs no jargon, and proves you looked past the website. **One fact. Then stop.**

Do not say

Any IRR, MoIC or fee rate · “perpetual capital” · “asset-light” · fund names beyond ARCC/ASIF · “I’m passionate about finance” · “market-leading platform” · that Ares is unaffected by the private credit downturn.

Practical

Quiet room with signal · water within reach · CV in front of you · pen and paper for her answers · **smile while you speak, it carries down a phone line** · pick up on the first ring · let her finish before you answer · if you lose signal, call back rather than waiting.

THE ONE-LINE SUMMARY

Be warm, be brief, know which team you want and why, and leave her thinking **“that person will interview well.”** That is the entire job of this call.